

Νικίας ὁ Ἀθηναῖος

Nicias of Athens and the Expedition to Syracuse

eul_aid: dkw

Period: *Κλασική* [Classical](#)

Dialect: *Ἀττική* [Attic](#)

Format: *Ἐπιστολή* [Epistle](#)

Nicias of Athens was a conservative Athenian statesman and general during the Peloponnesian War. He lived from approximately 470 to 413 BCE. His immense wealth, derived from silver mines at Laurium, funded public liturgies and bolstered his political standing as a leader of the peace party. He negotiated the Peace of Nicias in 421 BCE but is most infamous for his reluctant command of the Sicilian Expedition. His leadership was marked by fatal caution and superstition, culminating in catastrophic defeat and his execution in 413 BCE.

A single epistle is attributed to him: the Epistle to the Athenian Assembly. This fragmentary letter, sent during the Sicilian campaign to request reinforcements or recall, is preserved within the historical narratives of Thucydides and Plutarch but does not survive as an independent work.

Nicias is a pivotal figure of the Peloponnesian War. His career exemplifies the tension between cautious aristocratic leadership and aggressive populism in democratic Athens. The failure of the Sicilian Expedition under his command proved a decisive turning point toward Athens' ultimate defeat, making his story a classic study of character and military prudence in history.

Works (1)

- [Ἐπιστολή · Athenian Expedition to Syracuse](#) · 2 passages